
THE WORKBOOK

Project Management

Made Simple.

Frameworks and cheat sheets for anyone who got asked to run something and said yes.

A BEGINNER'S GUIDE TO GETTING THINGS DONE

TEAR. FILL. REPEAT.

Contents.

20 numbered pages · printable on Letter.

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Each chapter has two pages: the cheat sheet on the front and the worksheet on the back.

The Five Steps.

How a project moves from idea to done.

01

Define Clear Goals

CH. 01

Know exactly what you're here to do, in one sentence.

02

Break Down the Work

CH. 02

Slice the work into pieces a single person can pick up.

03

Plan Timelines & Resources

CH. 03

Best guesses written down, with owners and dates.

04

Communicate Effectively

CH. 04

Boring weekly updates beat surprise quarterly emails.

05

Monitor, Adapt & Finish Strong

CH. 05 — 06

Track what's stuck, end on purpose, write what you learned.

SMART Project Definition.

Specific. Measurable. Achievable. Relevant. Time-bound.

PROJECT _____ DATE _____

01 DEFINE THE PURPOSE

What specific goal or problem does this project address?

e.g. Three parks in the district have visible litter that's been there since fall.

02 DETERMINE THE IMPACT

What measurable value or difference will this project make?

e.g. 100+ residents involved, 3 parks cleaned, press coverage in local paper.

03 SET GOALS

What specific, measurable results define project success?

e.g. 3 parks cleaned, 100 volunteers, March 28, under \$1,000.

04 OUTLINE SUCCESS CRITERIA

What deliverables or benchmarks must be achieved to ensure success?

e.g. Permits secured by week 3 · supplies ordered by week 4 · 80+ volunteers signed up by day-of.

05 EVALUATE RISKS & REWARDS

BEST OUTCOME

Optimal result if you take action.

WORST OUTCOME

Consequences of not taking action.

One-Page Project Brief.

Pin everything down on one piece of paper. Refine as you learn.

PROJECT

e.g. Community Cleanup Day

OWNER

SPONSOR

DATE

VERSION

01 OBJECTIVE

e.g. Clean three parks in one Saturday with 100 volunteers, under \$1,000.

02 SCOPE

INCLUSIONS

-
-
-

EXCLUSIONS

-
-
-

03 PLAN

TIMELINE

Start

End

Milestones

RESOURCES

People

Tools

Materials

BUDGET

Planned

Buffer

Total

\$

\$

\$

04 SUCCESS CRITERIA

e.g. 3 parks cleaned · 100 volunteers · under budget.

-
-
-

05 RISKS & MITIGATION

e.g. Rain → rain plan. Low signups → partner outreach.

-
-
-

06 STAKEHOLDERS

e.g. Sponsor, parks supervisor, volunteer coordinator, press contact.

-
-

Weekly Status Update.

Boring wins. Same day, same format, every week.

PROJECT _____

WEEK OF _____

REVIEWED WITH _____

STATUS

☐

Green

☐

Amber

☐

Red

ONE-LINE READ _____

e.g. "Amber. Permit delayed one week, deciding Friday whether to move sites."

01 PROGRESS _____

e.g. Outcomes that moved, not tasks you completed.

— _____
— _____
— _____

02 RISKS & BLOCKERS _____

e.g. By name. "Awaiting feedback" is not a blocker.

— _____
— _____
— _____

03 DECISIONS NEEDED _____

e.g. A decision with no deadline is a decision not yet made.

DECISION

OWNER

BY WHEN

_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____

04 NEXT WEEK _____

e.g. What you're doing, not what you hope happens.

— _____
— _____
— _____

RACI.

Who does, who decides, who advises, who hears about it.

PROJECT

DATE

R RESPONSIBLE Does the work.	A ACCOUNTABLE Makes the call. Signs off.	C CONSULTED Gives input.	I INFORMED Kept in the loop.
--	--	--	--

The one rule. Exactly one A per row. If four people are accountable, zero people are.

TASK	R	A	C	I

e.g. tasks · Secure permits · Recruit volunteers · Order supplies · Coordinate press · Brief sponsor.

Lessons Learned.

Celebrate first. Then write down what you know now that you didn't at the start.

PROJECT

CLOSED ON

PARTICIPANTS

HIT THE CHARTER?

☐ Yes

☐ Partly

☐ No

NOTES

01

WHAT WENT WELL

e.g. Be specific. "The team was great" isn't a lesson.

02

WHAT DIDN'T

e.g. Honest, not personal. Focus on what happened, not who.

03

WHAT WE'LL CHANGE

e.g. A lesson with no owner is a sigh. Assign every change.

CHANGE / ACTION	OWNER	BY WHEN

Stakeholder Map.

Sort people by how much they shape the project, and how much they care.

PROJECT _____ DATE _____

	← LOW INTEREST	INTEREST	HIGH INTEREST →
↑ HIGH INFLUENCE	Keep Satisfied <i>Concise updates. Focus on outcomes.</i> - _____ - _____ - _____ - _____	Manage Closely <i>Involve in key decisions. Keep on speed dial.</i> - _____ - _____ - _____ - _____	
↓ LOW INFLUENCE	Monitor <i>Light touch. Watch only.</i> - _____ - _____ - _____ - _____	Keep Informed <i>Keep in the loop. Invite feedback.</i> - _____ - _____ - _____ - _____	

Tip. Talk to the quietest stakeholders first, not last. They're where the surprises live.

Risk Matrix.

Map your top risks, then plan responses for the ones in the corner.

PROJECT

DATE

HIGH PROB MED PROB LOW PROB	Moderate	Serious	Critical
	Monitor	Moderate	Serious
	Little	Monitor	Moderate
	LOW IMPACT	MED IMPACT	HIGH IMPACT

Plot each risk in the right cell. Spend the most time on the deep corner. Re-rank weekly.

RISK LOG		TOP 5 RISKS, BY DEEPEST CORNER FIRST		
	RISK	P	I	RESPONSE · OWNER
01				
02				
03				
04				
05				

Start With Why.

Before you plan anything, know what you're actually here to do.

BIG IDEAS

e.g. Clean three parks in one Saturday, with 100 volunteers, for under \$1,000.

- | | |
|--|--|
| <p>01 A project has a beginning, a middle, and an end. Ongoing work is not a project.</p> <p>02 If you can't say why the work matters in one sentence, don't start yet.</p> <p>03 The best charter fits on a napkin, not a PDF. Edit until it does.</p> | <p>04 Success is a measurable outcome, not a feeling or a finished deck.</p> <p>05 Scope is what you are doing. Out-of-scope is what you're not. Write both down.</p> <p>06 The sponsor is the person who can kill the project. Know who that is.</p> |
|--|--|

DO THIS

e.g. "Three parks cleaned, 100 volunteers, March 28, under \$1,000."

- ✓ Name the project in five words or fewer.
- ✓ Write the outcome as something you can measure.
- ✓ Get one sponsor who will say yes or no when asked.
- ✓ Write down what's out of scope before anyone asks.

AVOID THIS

e.g. "Improve community engagement through outdoor beautification initiatives."

- × Vague outcomes nobody can tell you've hit.
- × Collecting sponsors. One decisive person beats six advisors.
- × Starting work before anyone has said why.
- × Letting the scope grow every time someone has a good idea.

Start With Why.

PROJECT _____ DATE _____

TRY IT _____

Write your one-sentence why. Keep editing until it fits in the space.

e.g. Community Cleanup Day, March 28.

First pass. Don't overthink it. Scratch out what comes first.

Final pass. Rewrite cleaner. This is what you'd show the sponsor.

Know Your People.

Projects are made of decisions. Decisions are made by people. Map them.

BIG IDEAS

e.g. A mayor who wants a photo-op isn't the same stakeholder as a parks supervisor.

- | | |
|---|---|
| <p>01 Every project has more stakeholders than you think. Write them all down once.</p> <p>02 Stakeholders want different things. That's normal. Name the differences.</p> <p>03 A RACI chart is not paperwork, it's a fight you're having in advance.</p> | <p>04 The person doing the work and the person accountable are rarely the same.</p> <p>05 Consulted ≠ informed. Tell someone the difference before they complain.</p> <p>06 If four people are accountable, zero people are accountable.</p> |
|---|---|

DO THIS

e.g. List the park supervisor, the sponsor, the volunteer coordinator, the press contact.

- ✓ List everyone who could slow this down or help it move.
- ✓ For each person, write what they want out of this.
- ✓ Mark exactly one Accountable per decision.
- ✓ Talk to the quietest stakeholders first, not last.

AVOID THIS

e.g. Treating "the city" as one stakeholder is how you get three conflicting approvals.

- × Grouping people by org chart instead of by what they actually care about.
- × Assuming silence means agreement. It almost never does.
- × Saving the difficult stakeholder for last.
- × Letting the loudest voice set the priorities.

Know Your People.

PROJECT _____ DATE _____

TRY IT _____

List five stakeholders, ordered by how nervous the conversation makes you.

e.g. Five names, from easiest to hardest conversation.

First pass. Don't overthink it. Scratch out what comes first.

1. _____

2. _____

3. _____

4. _____

5. _____

Final pass. Rewrite cleaner. This is what you'd show the sponsor.

1. _____

2. _____

3. _____

4. _____

Plan Without Panic.

A plan is a best guess written down. You'll change it. Write it anyway.

BIG IDEAS

e.g. Trash bags arrive Thursday. Volunteers arrive Saturday. Don't flip those.

- | | |
|---|---|
| <p>01 A good plan answers what, when, and who, in that order.</p> <p>02 If a task has no owner, it has no chance. Assign everything.</p> <p>03 Estimate in ranges, not single dates. Everyone knows dates lie.</p> | <p>04 The critical path is the short list of things that actually set your deadline.</p> <p>05 Buffers aren't laziness. They're how real projects finish on time.</p> <p>06 Break work down until the next step is obvious to whoever picks it up.</p> |
|---|---|

DO THIS

e.g. Book porta-potties before you recruit volunteers. Constraints first.

- ✓ Start with the fixed date, then work backward.
- ✓ Put owner names, not teams, next to every task.
- ✓ Pad the things you've never done before.
- ✓ Identify the three tasks that, if late, move the deadline.

AVOID THIS

e.g. A Gantt chart with 212 rows and no owners. Pretty, useless.

- ✗ Planning in a tool no one on the project will open again.
- ✗ Estimating in hours when the work happens over weeks.
- ✗ Hiding the critical path inside a bigger list.
- ✗ Spending more time planning than the project will take.

Plan Without Panic.

PROJECT _____ DATE _____

TRY IT _____

Write your top four tasks in the order they must happen. Owners next to each.

e.g. Secure permit · confirm venues · recruit volunteers · order supplies.

First pass. *Don't overthink it. Scratch out what comes first.*

1. _____

2. _____

3. _____

4. _____

Final pass. *Rewrite cleaner. This is what you'd show the sponsor.*

1. _____

2. _____

3. _____

4. _____

Track The Real Work.

The point of a status update is surfacing what's stuck, not performing progress.

BIG IDEAS

e.g. Green doesn't mean busy. It means the outcome is still on track.

- | | |
|---|--|
| <p>01 A weekly status is 10 minutes of writing that saves hours of meetings.</p> <p>02 Green/Amber/Red is a forecast, not a mood. Be honest early.</p> <p>03 If your status has been green for six weeks, one of two things is true.</p> | <p>04 A decision with no deadline is a decision that hasn't been made.</p> <p>05 List blockers by name. "Awaiting feedback" is not a blocker.</p> <p>06 Update the same people, on the same day, in the same format. Boring wins.</p> |
|---|--|

DO THIS

e.g. "Amber. Permit delayed by one week, deciding Friday whether to move sites."

- ✓ Send status the same weekday every week, even when nothing moved.
- ✓ Rate the outcome, not how busy you've been.
- ✓ Every Decision Needed gets a person and a date.
- ✓ Say "I need X by Y" when you need something.

AVOID THIS

e.g. Eight green updates in a row, then a surprise red. Everyone has seen that movie.

- × Listing tasks completed instead of outcomes on track.
- × Going amber on Friday instead of the Monday you first worried.
- × Writing "on track" with no evidence. Show the signal.
- × Burying the one thing the sponsor needs to act on.

Track The Real Work.

PROJECT _____ DATE _____

TRY IT _____

Draft this week's update, using only these four headings. Two lines per heading, max.

e.g. Done · doing · blocked · decisions needed.

First pass. *Don't overthink it. Scratch out what comes first.*

Final pass. *Rewrite cleaner. This is what you'd show the sponsor.*

When Things Go Sideways.

They will. The only question is whether you saw it coming.

BIG IDEAS

e.g. Rain on March 28 isn't a surprise. Not having a rain plan is.

- | | |
|--|---|
| <p>01 A risk is a future problem that hasn't happened yet. Write it down anyway.</p> <p>02 Probability × Impact tells you what to worry about first.</p> <p>03 Every risk needs an owner. Shared risks are unowned risks.</p> | <p>04 Response options: avoid, reduce, transfer, accept. Pick one per risk.</p> <p>05 The risks you won't write down are usually the ones that get you.</p> <p>06 A risk that becomes reality is no longer a risk. It's an issue. Change the column.</p> |
|--|---|

DO THIS

e.g. Weather · volunteer no-shows · permit denial · supply shortage.

- ✓ List your top five risks at project start. Update weekly.
- ✓ Name one owner per risk. First name is fine.
- ✓ Write the response plan before you need it.
- ✓ Re-rank after every status update. Priorities change.

AVOID THIS

e.g. A risk log written once on day one and never opened again.

- × Vague risks. "Scope creep" isn't a risk, it's a category.
- × Impact without probability. A 0.1% disaster doesn't beat a likely delay.
- × Treating the risk log as a document instead of a living tool.
- × Planning only for the risks you're comfortable discussing.

When Things Go Sideways.

PROJECT _____ DATE _____

TRY IT _____

Name your top three risks. For each, write the owner and one response.

e.g. Rain, no-shows, permit, supplies, press cancellation.

First pass. Don't overthink it. Scratch out what comes first.

1. _____

2. _____

3. _____

Final pass. Rewrite cleaner. This is what you'd show the sponsor.

1. _____

2. _____

3. _____

Finish And Learn.

The project ends when you decide it ends, and write down what you know now.

BIG IDEAS

e.g. Three parks cleaned, 87 volunteers turned out, \$842 spent, one lost phone.

- | | |
|---|--|
| <p>01 A project isn't done until someone says "done" out loud, in writing.</p> <p>02 Compare what happened to the charter. That's your success criteria, not vibes.</p> <p>03 Lessons learned that stay in your head help no one. Write them down.</p> | <p>04 Celebrate before you debrief. Tired people don't learn; grateful ones do.</p> <p>05 Separate "what went well" from "what we'll change." Don't mix them in the meeting.</p> <p>06 Every lesson learned should become an action with an owner and a date.</p> |
|---|--|

DO THIS

e.g. Debrief Tuesday at the community center. Bring coffee. Cap at 45 minutes.

- ✓ Schedule the closeout meeting before the project starts.
- ✓ Send the lessons doc to the next PM who'll run something like this.
- ✓ Write actions, not observations. "Book permits 6 weeks earlier" beats "permits were late."
- ✓ Archive the charter, status logs, and risk log together.

AVOID THIS

e.g. A "how did it go?" email that gets three replies and disappears.

- ✗ Skipping the debrief because the project technically worked.
- ✗ Turning the retro into a blame meeting. It never comes back from that.
- ✗ Generic lessons nobody will act on next time.
- ✗ Treating closeout as optional. It's where the compounding happens.

Finish And Learn.

PROJECT _____ DATE _____

TRY IT _____

Three wins, three things to change, and who owns each change.

e.g. Went well · didn't · will change · owner.

First pass. *Don't overthink it. Scratch out what comes first.*

- ☐ _____
- ☐ _____
- ☐ _____
- ☐ _____
- ☐ _____
- ☐ _____

Final pass. *Rewrite cleaner. This is what you'd show the sponsor.*

- ☐ _____
- ☐ _____
- ☐ _____
- ☐ _____
- ☐ _____
- ☐ _____